BEFORE WE BEGIN · ABOUT 600 BC

The Silver Scrolls of Ketef Hinnom



Photo: Ketef Hinnom Silver Scrolls · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

The oldest Bible words ever found are the blessing you hear at the end of the service.

> The LORD bless thee, and keep thee: The LORD make his face shine upon thee, and be gracious unto thee: The LORD lift up his countenance upon thee, and give thee peace.
>
> NUMBERS 6:24–26 · KJV

FOUND
1979, a burial cave on the hillside of Ketef Hinnom, across the valley from Mount Zion, Jerusalem

SEE IT TODAY
The Israel Museum, Jerusalem

What it is

Two tiny rolls of silver, the larger under four inches long when flat. A family in Jerusalem wore them as charms and buried them with their dead. Gabriel Barkay's dig found the cave in 1979; a 13-year-old volunteer was the one who uncovered the hiding place under the floor. Unrolling the brittle silver at the Israel Museum took about three years.

What it shows

Scratched into the silver is a short form of the priestly blessing, with the name of the LORD. These are the oldest known words that also stand in our Bible, roughly four centuries older than the Dead Sea Scrolls. A family was carrying this blessing before Jerusalem fell to Babylon.

What scholars still ask

A few scholars once dated the scrolls much later. New photographs made in 2004 supported the date of about 600 BC, which most now accept. The wording is a shorter form of the blessing, not a copy taken from a scroll of Numbers.

TALK ABOUT IT

Why might a family have wanted these words on their body, every day?

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